



(EXTREME LEFT) KULASI MANDAL SHOWS HER WOUND; (LEFT) HUMAN BEINGS AND CATTLE MOVE AROUND UNMINDFUL OF A 6-METRE-LONG CROCODILE BASKING ON THE RIVER BANK IN GUPTI

Close Encounters of the Reptilian Kind

DEATH TOLL

According to official estimates, between 1996 and 2008, 17 persons and 46 animals were killed by crocodiles. Officials at the Bhitarkanika Wildlife Sanctuary say that adult crocodiles, under normal circumstances, never leave their territory to chase their prey unlike terrestrial predatory animals like tigers. Most of the deaths occur when the victims intrude into the crocodile's habitat for illegal fishing.



hands and legs missing," says Ganesh, who did not report the incident. "Many such cases go unreported due to fear of officials," says Sudershan Pradhan from Gupti, who also lost his pregnant wife Gauri Bala to one of the deadly reptiles.

The reason for this apparent indifference to human casualty is that forest officials are emotionally attached to the crocodile project and want to get the core area cleared of all human activity. They have a reason to feel strongly about the reptile. Even though saltwater crocodiles have disappeared from rest of India, these forest officials have been working hard to maintain its population: the number of crocodiles increased to 1,498 in 2007-08 from 1,358 in 2003-04. The population growth within the 145-sq km core area is making food scarce for the giant-sized reptiles.

However, wildlife experts are worried over the rising number of crocodiles. "The forest department has been following a wrong policy," says Biswajit Mohanty, secretary, Wildlife Society of Orissa. Most of the crocodiles are parked in the Dangamal area of the park. The real problem will start once the Rengali dam in Angul-Deogarh area, 200 km north of Dangamal, becomes functional. As water will be released, fresh water flow will be restricted and salinity will increase. The crocodiles will travel upstream threatening human habitats. The areas likely to be affected most by crocodile invasion are Pattamundai, Indupur and Aul. "This will end the mangrove forests because they need both fresh and saline water," says Mohanty. Mangroves are, in fact, a unique group of plant life that flourish only in the areas falling between high and low tide zone of an es-

tuary. Sunderbans is the largest in the country, but is hit hard by degradation. Mangrove forests are also found in Goa and the Gulf of Kutch in Gujarat but Kendrapara's mangrove forests, with 30 species of reptiles, 177 species of birds and 27 species of mammals, are very dense. "The society has been taking up the issue with the Central and the state government as well as National Board for Wildlife since 2006. But no action has been taken so far," adds Mohanty.

Undoubtedly, the endangered species needs protection, but the authorities must ensure safety for the people in the surrounding areas. For the moment, they seem to be only shedding crocodile tears over the fatal encounters in the park.

For more wildlife pictures click on:
www.indiatoday.in/bhitarkanika

